Print or Textual Analysis: What You Read

16

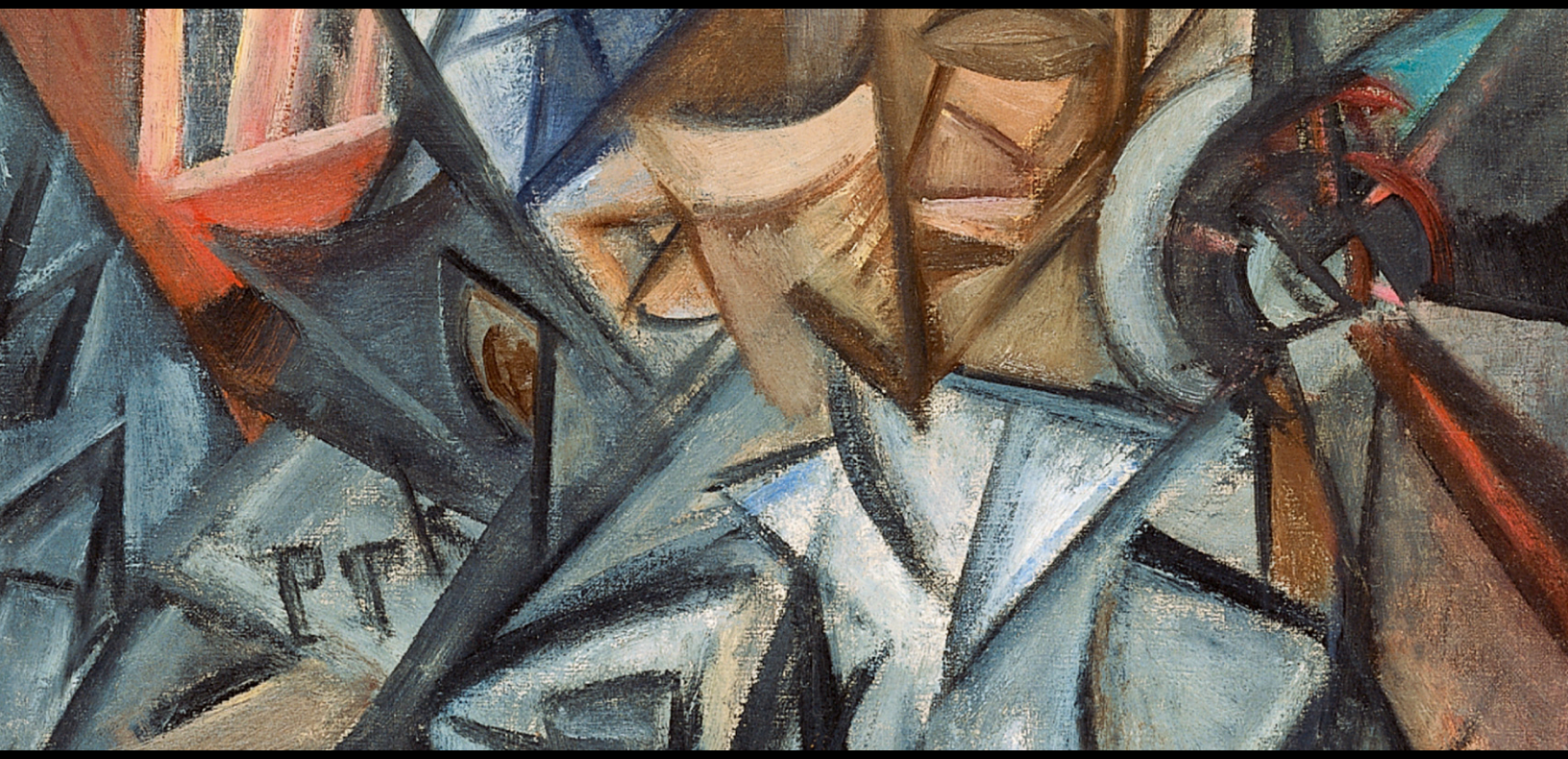


FIGURE 16.1 Consider the subject of this painting, *Man on the Street*, by Russian artist Olga Rozanova (1886–1918). Now, consider the way the subject is presented: cool colors, fragmented lines, distorted perspective. *What is the artist saying about the man on the street by presenting him in this way?* As soon as you begin to answer this question, you are analyzing a visual text. When you read a story, you might ask the following questions: *Why does this character act this way? How would the story be different if it were set in another time or place? What is the author saying about life in general? How does the author make these points?* When you begin to answer these questions about a work of fiction or literary nonfiction, you are analyzing a literary text. (credit: "Man on the Street (Analysis of Volumes)" by Olga Rozanova/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

CHAPTER OUTLINE

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INTRODUCTION In the real world, you are surrounded by text—both visual and print. It appears in media, advertising, and even text messages. Often, text is not one-dimensional, in the sense that words and the ways in which they are used or arranged can have different meanings depending on the relationship between the text and the reader. In such cases, a text is open to analysis and interpretation. Usually, there is no one right

way to analyze and interpret a text; readers, like viewers, may understand elements in different ways and draw different conclusions. Whatever they are, however, will be the result of reading critically: examining parts of the text as they relate to the whole, supporting ideas with evidence, and drawing conclusions on the basis of analysis.

The practice of analysis will benefit you in several ways. It can help you enter an ongoing conversation with a new and fresh perspective. It also can help you understand meaning beyond the surface of a text—including historical contexts and cultures, new approaches to thinking, and new knowledge.

Although the word *text* tends to imply words, writing, or books, virtually all works created by human beings can be considered texts that are open to analysis—films, plays, music and dance performances, exhibits, paintings, photographs, sculptures, advertisements, artifacts, buildings, and even whole cultures. In this chapter, you will focus on the analysis of print texts. In Image Analysis: What You See, you will move to the analysis of visual and digital texts.

16.1 An Author's Choices: What Text Says and How It Says It

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Define *textual analysis* and explain its place in academic and real-world contexts.
- Identify the components of textual analysis and compare it to rhetorical analysis.
- Demonstrate critical thinking and communicating in various rhetorical contexts.

You may already be familiar with what is called **textual analysis** in academia. In fact, you do it frequently when you read or interact in other ways with language. It is important, though, to distinguish between what textual analysis *is* and what it is *not*. For example, imagine you and a friend have just finished watching a TV show or movie. You'll probably say whether you liked it and what in particular prompted your opinion. This brief and casual opinion-based conversation is just that, a casual conversation. It is *not* analysis, which goes far beyond liking or disliking a text. Perhaps you continue your conversation. *Do you and your friend agree that everything in the show is obvious and clear or is inconsistent and muddy—characters' motivations, their development over the course of the story, how the setting affects the story, the point the story is making, the extent to which the characters seem realistic or relatable, whether the dialogue seems natural, or any other elements? Or do you and your friend view some of these elements differently? Do you have different views about what you think is the main idea or what a character represents? For instance, do you think the main character represents a force of good, while your friend thinks the main character is a boring wimp?* If you agreed on everything—and everything seems straightforward—then that's that: the film offers little to interpret and most likely is not a strong text for analysis because it doesn't invite interpretation. However, if you *do* have questions about some of the elements or disagree about them, then you are on your way to analyzing and interpreting a text.

Analyzing and Interpreting

What exactly, then, is textual analysis? To analyze a text is to examine its various parts to explain its meaning. Analyzing a text implies that the text can be read in more than one way. Your analysis is your reading of it: your explanation of various text elements, your understanding of the text, and how you understand it in a larger context. Others may read and understand it differently. To find out what a text—fiction or nonfiction—means, you look at its language, examine how it is put together, perhaps compare or contrast it with similar texts or other works, and notice how it affects you or how it fits into events outside it, and you keep asking *why*. Always keep in mind, however, that a textual analysis is not about whether you like a text; it is about the meaning of the text—how the author created it and intended it to be understood.

Any written work can be analyzed as a text. But an editorial or opinion piece or something written, for example, as part of an ongoing argument of viewpoints is more likely to be looked at for the rhetorical or persuasive strategies it employs to create or change an opinion. (This kind of rhetorical analysis is the focus of

Rhetorical Analysis: Interpreting the Art of Rhetoric.) Literary works, whether fiction or nonfiction, film or text, print or digital, are those analyzed as texts. Their impact on real events in real life is likely less direct than that of rhetorical, or persuasive, writing, but many characters and themes that "live" in these works tend to exist for a very long time and are open to analysis as part of a person's growth and education—and even more, a part of and a reflection of the human condition.

Writers have many options when considering what to say and how to say it. The best texts for analysis are those that are most problematic—texts whose meanings seem elusive or complex—because these texts give you the most room to argue for one meaning over another. Like your goal in rhetorical analysis, your goal in textual analysis is to make the best possible case to demonstrate to readers that your analysis is reasonable and deserves serious attention. Remember, too, that *argument* in academic terms means taking a position and supporting it. Therefore, when you analyze a text, you take a position on an aspect (or several aspects) of that text and support it with evidence from the text itself and, if applicable, from borrowed sources, which you acknowledge.

Textual analysis is a complex task that draws on your critical reading, reasoning, and writing skills. Depending on your topic and thesis, you may have to describe real or fictional people and situations, retell events, define key terms, analyze passages and explain how they work in relation to the whole, and examine and interpret contexts and themes—perhaps by comparing or contrasting the text with other texts. Finally, you will "argue" for the meaning as you understand it, rather than another possible meaning. In other words, as you do for most academic writing, you develop a thesis and defend it with sound reasoning and convincing textual evidence.



16.2 Trailblazer

Textual Analysis Trailblazer: bell hooks

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Demonstrate critical thinking and communicating in varying rhetorical and cultural contexts.
- Integrate the writer's ideas with ideas of others.



FIGURE 16.2 bell hooks (https://openstax.org/r/bell-hooks) (credit: "Bellhooks" by Cmongirl/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

"Writing and performing should deepen the meaning of words, should illuminate, transfix, and transform."

Talking Back

Born Gloria Jean Watkins, bell hooks adopted the name of her great-grandmother, a woman known for speaking her mind. In choosing this pen name, hooks decided not to capitalize the first letters so that audiences would focus on her work rather than her name. However, this stylistic choice has become as memorable as her work.

She is well known for her approach to social critique through textual analysis. The writing interests and research methods hooks uses are wide ranging. They began in poetry and fiction writing and eventually developed into critical analysis. She started writing at an early age, as her teachers (in the church) impressed on hooks the power in language. With this exposure to language, hooks began to understand the "sacredness of words" and began to write poetry and fiction. Over time, hooks's writing became more focused on advancing and reviving the texts of Black women and women of color, for even though "black women and women of color are publishing more... there is still not enough" writing by and about them. Texts live on through others' analyses, hooks argues. Therefore, she believes the critical essay "is the most useful form for the expression" between her thoughts and the books she is reading. The critical essay allows hooks to create a dialogue, or "talk back" to the text. The critical essay also extends "the conversations I have with other critical thinkers." It is this "talking back" that has advanced hooks's approach to literary criticism. This action, for which hooks eventually named a volume of essays, refers to the development of a strong sense of self that allows Black women to speak out against racism and sexism.

Although young hooks continued to write poetry—some of which was published—she gained a reputation as a writer of critical essays about systems of domination. She began writing her first book, *Ain't I a Woman: Black Women and Feminism*, when she was 19 and an undergraduate student at Stanford University. The book is titled after Sojourner Truth's (1797–1883) "Ain't I a Woman" speech (https://openstax.org/r/Aint-I-a-Woman) given at the Woman's Rights Convention in Akron, Ohio, in 1851. In this work, hooks examines the effects of racism and sexism on Black women, the civil rights movement, and feminist movements from suffrage to the 1970s. By "talking back" to formerly enslaved abolitionist Sojourner Truth throughout, hooks identifies ways in which feminist movements have failed to focus on Black women and women of color. This work is one of many in which thorough analysis "uncovered" the lived experiences of Black women and women of color.

Discussion Questions

1. What are your thoughts about hooks's approach to analysis through "talking back" to a text? What might this approach look like in an essay or text: how might you "talk back"?
2. What purpose does hooks's approach to entering into conversation with other critical thinkers through critical analysis serve?
3. Much of hooks's work is based on her goal of "reviving" and "uncovering" historically marginalized women's voices. In what ways does critical analysis highlight the work of others?

16.3 Glance at Genre: Print or Textual Analysis

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Define key terms and organizational patterns of textual analysis.
- Explain how genre conventions are shaped by purpose, culture, and expectation.

As a **genre**—or literary category in which works feature similar forms, styles, or subject matter—textual analysis is less of a genre in itself and more of an exploration and interpretation of other genres. That is, textual analysis is explanatory and interpretive. When you receive an assignment to analyze a text, you focus on the elements that give it meaning. Usually your instructor will assign a specific writing task: to analyze and explain certain aspects of a text, to compare or contrast certain elements within a single text or in two or more texts, or to relate certain text elements to historical context or current events (as student writer Gwyn Garrison has done in the Annotated Student Sample). These writing tasks thus explore genre characteristics of fiction, drama, poetry, literary nonfiction, film, and other forms of literary language.

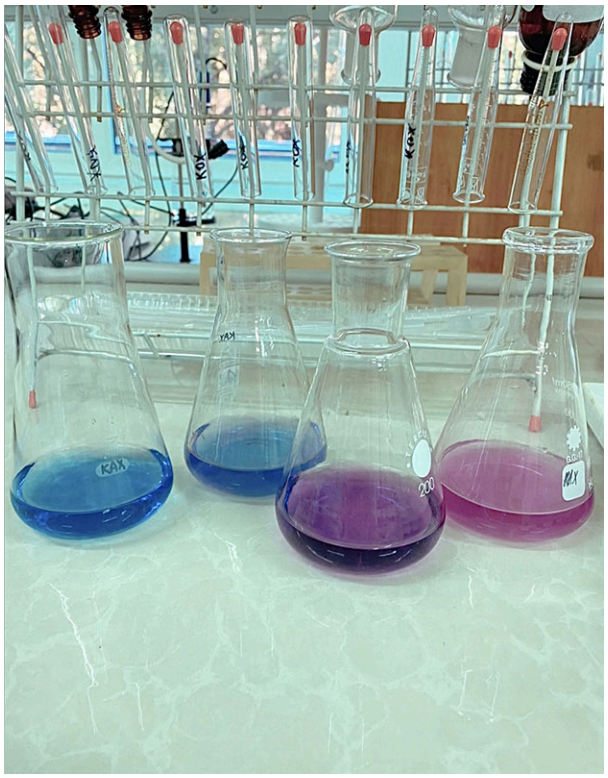


FIGURE 16.3 Like scientists who analyze components of a substance, writers of textual analysis examine a fiction or literary nonfiction work to understand and interpret its meaning by looking at its components. (credit: "Complexometric titration" by Alina.Popova.26/Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 4.0)

When you write a textual analysis, ask yourself questions such as these:

- In what ways can this text be read?
- What are some different ways of reading it?
- Which reading makes the most sense to me?
- Which passages in the text support this reading?
- Whom does my analysis need to convince? (Who is my audience?)

Textual Analysis and Interpretive Communities

How you read and analyze a text depends on who you are. Who you are depends on the influences that have shaped you, or the communities to which you belong. Everyone belongs to various communities: families, social and economic groups (e.g., students or teachers, middle or working class), organizations (e.g., Democratic or Republican Party, Masons, Habitat for Humanity), geographic locales (e.g., rural or urban, north or south), and institutions (e.g., school, church, fraternity). Your membership in one or more communities may determine how you view and respond to the world. The communities that influence you most are called **interpretive communities**; they influence the meaning you make of the world. People who belong to the same community may well have similar assumptions and therefore are likely to analyze texts in similar ways.

Before writing an interpretive or textual analysis essay, it is helpful to ask, *Who am I when writing this piece?* Be aware of your age, gender, race, ethnic identity, economic class, geographic location, educational level, or political or religious persuasion. Ask to what extent and for what purpose any of these identities emerges in your writing. Readers will examine the biases you may bring to your work, understanding that everyone views the world—and, consequently, texts—from their own vantage point.

College is, of course, a large interpretive community. The various smaller communities that exist within it are called disciplines: English, history, biology, business, art, and so on. Established ways of interpreting texts exist within disciplines. Often when you write a textual analysis, you will do so from the perspective of a traditional academic interpretive community or from the perspective of one who challenges that community.

Whether you deliberately identify yourself and any biases you might bring with you in your essay depends on the assignment you are given. Some assignments ask you to remove your personal perspective as much as possible from your writing, others ask that you acknowledge and explain it, and others fall somewhere in between.



FIGURE 16.4 The individuals in this group of student volunteers and staff represent both similar and different cultural and interpretive communities. (credit: “Alternative Spring Break (ASB) group from Rice University, volunteer

at Mason Neck State Park" by Virginia State Parks/Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 2.0)

Conventions of Textual Analysis

When asked to analyze or interpret a literary work, whether fiction or nonfiction, you will likely focus on some of these literary elements to explain how an author uses them to make meaning.

- **Alliteration:** literary device consisting of repetition of initial consonant sounds. ("Away from the steamy sidewalk, the children sat in a circle.")
- **Analysis:** close examination and explanation of a text, supported by reasoning and evidence.
- **Antagonist:** character or force opposing the main character (protagonist) in a story.
- **Climax:** moment of emotional or intellectual intensity or a point in the plot when one opposing force overcomes another and the conflict is resolved.
- **Epiphany:** flash of intuitive understanding by the narrator or a character in a story.
- **Figurative language:** language that suggests special meanings or effects. Similes and metaphors are examples of figurative, rather than literal, language. ("She stands like a tree, solid and rooted.")
- **Imagery:** language that appeals to one (or more) of the five senses. ("The cicadas hummed nonstop all day, but never loud enough to dull the roar of the leaf blowers.)
- **Metaphor:** direct comparison between two unlike things. ("She is a sly fox in her undercover work for the government.")
- **Narrator:** someone who tells a story. A character narrator is a part of the story, whereas an omniscient narrator tells a story about others.
- **Persona:** mask to disguise or cover the author's real self when presenting a story or other literary work.
- **Plot:** sequence of events in a story or play.
- **Point of view:** vantage point from which a story or event is perceived and told. The most frequently used points of view are first person and third person. In first person, the narrator is a character or observer in the story (fiction) or the author of it (nonfiction). In third person, the narrator has no part in the story other than telling it.
- **Protagonist:** main character or hero in a story.
- **Rhyme:** repetition of sounds, usually at the ends of lines in poems, but also occurring at other intervals in a line.
- **Rhythm:** rise and fall of stressed sounds within sentences, paragraphs, and stanzas.
- **Simile:** indirect comparison of unlike things using the word *as* or *like*. ("When he does undercover work, he is as sly as a fox.")
- **Symbol:** object that represents itself and something else at the same time. A red rose is both a rose of a certain color and the suggestion of something romantic.
- **Theme:** meaning or thesis of a literary text.

16.4 Annotated Student Sample: "Artists at Work" by Gwyn Garrison

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Demonstrate understanding of how conventions are shaped by purpose, language, culture, and expectation.
- Demonstrate critical thinking and communicating in varying rhetorical and cultural contexts.
- Make connections between ideas and patterns of organization.
- Evaluate literary elements and strategies used in textual analysis.

Introduction

Student Gwyn Garrison wrote this textual analysis for a first-year composition class. In the essay, Garrison extends her analysis beyond the texts to discuss outside events and real individuals, making connections among them.

LIVING BY THEIR OWN WORDS

The Power of Language

Language is the medium through which the communication of ideas takes place. One of language's many attributes is its ability both to reflect and to shape social attitudes. Language has the power to perpetuate oppression when dominant social groups choose the ways in which rebellious behavior is described. Thus, people in power historically have used language as propaganda to perpetuate the ideas that they want to reiterate. For example, if a woman in modern society is described as *ladylike,* the message is that she conforms to traditional gender expectations of politeness, modesty, and deference. However, if a woman is called a *whore,* the message is that the woman does not conform to these traditional gender standards. In recent years, oppressed social groups have learned that they can reclaim the language of the oppressor by redefining such words and their connotations.

Gwyn Garrison uses reaction—reflection or thinking—to introduce the "big idea" of the thesis: language has the power to shape cultural and social attitudes.

> American authors such as Kate Chopin and Shirley Jackson, sociopolitical activists such as Hillary Clinton and Chrissy Teigen, and California rape survivor Chanel Miller— artists/writers in their own ways—take on this essential work of reclaiming language on behalf of all women. This confiscation of the tools of the oppressor is an essential step toward building a society in which women may be free to be who they are. Negative stereotypical labeling no longer has the effect of disempowering women because language can be reclaimed from the oppressor as a form of empowerment.

Garrison's thesis statement highlights her analytical approach. She makes a connection between women's rights and a series of texts by significant women.

> Writers can use the short story form to shift perception away from the lens of the status quo and focus perception in a new way. In Kate Chopin's 1898 short story "The Storm" (text follows this discussion), protagonist Calixta engages in a passionate extramarital affair with an old friend, Alcée. Readers may argue that Calixta's actions should be labeled as immoral by both societal and religious standards because she breaks the social and religious contract defined by her marriage vows. Yet every other action of Calixta's complies with traditional gender roles: she is a wife, mother, and caretaker. In some ways, committing this one social transgression seems completely out of character when she meets traditional gender expectations in all other areas of her life.

Garrison provides publication information as well as a brief plot summary and context for the story. You can read "The Storm" in its entirety at the end of this feature.

> When Calixta acts outside of societal norms, however, she discovers the freedom of self-expression and passion.

This transitional topic sentence supports the overall thesis while also identifying what the paragraph will be about.

> All parts of her womanhood that have no place in the society in which she lives have been repressed until this one moment. In this scene, Chopin takes possession of the term *whore* and redefines Calixta's behavior as a transformative awakening.

This explanation makes a reference to the language of the text and explains the significance of the scene as it relates to the entire story and to Garrison's thesis.

> Chopin's diction evokes a spiritual transcendence that allows Calixta to live momentarily outside social norms present only in the physical plane of existence: "when he possessed her, they seemed to swoon together at the very borderland of life's mystery."

Here, Garrison correctly cites textual evidence—an example of the protagonist's diction— to support her reasoning.

> The affair becomes a vehicle that allows Calixta to get to a place of true self-expression. The storm, an aspect of nature or the natural world, acts as the catalyst in Calixta's natural self-realization of womanhood. As the storm breaks externally, it also breaks internally for Calixta. Chopin's depiction of Calixta's sexual liberation and fulfillment outside of her marriage is an early step in the fight to bridge the gap between women's bodies and their sociopolitical lives. By presenting female sexuality in a way that is enlightening rather than degrading, Chopin helps destigmatize labels such as *whore,* which have been used to shame women for acting outside of traditional gender expectations.

Garrison further elaborates on the significance of the textual evidence and connects it to the topic sentence and thesis. In this case, it is the storm—an element of both plot and setting as well as a symbol.

> In Shirley Jackson's novel *We Have Always Lived in the Castle,* Merricat and her sister Constance are rumored to be witches who, according to village gossip, eat children. The label of *witch* has long been a device to oppress women who do not conform to traditional gender roles. In Salem, Massachusetts, during the 17th-century witch trials, women who could read or write, who refused marriage, or who practiced alternative religions often were labeled as witches and burned to death.

Introducing a second text for comparison, Garrison revisits the idea of language reclamation introduced earlier.

> In Jackson's novel, Merricat embraces the notion of being labeled a witch. In fact, she facilitates the rumors by burying talismans, identifying magical words, and talking to her cat, Jonas. In contrast to the witch trials, Merricat burns her own house to rid it of her male cousin. And she survives the fire, purging herself and her sister of the family's patriarchal tendencies. By claiming the role of witch, Merricat insulates herself and her sister from their patriarchal family and society. In the end, Merricat creates a space where she and Constance can live together in a woman-centered territory outside the reach of the villagers.

Focusing on language and its implications, Garrison discusses the use of witch, a label the character is happy to embrace as a means of asserting her womanhood.

> With this story, Jackson does the important work of reclaiming the word *witch,* stripping it of its oppressive power and redefining it for womankind.

In the section that follows, Garrison moves outside literary texts and extends her analysis to language use in contemporary political situations, thus connecting literature with reality. Notice that Garrison has used the literary present tense in discussing both Chopin's and Jackson's fiction. She switches and uses mostly past tense now in discussing nonliterary events.

> Similarly, in a more recent political climate, former U.S. president Donald Trump employed stereotypical derogatory language against women whom he considered dissenters. He used phrases like "such a nasty woman" (Ali) to describe former Secretary of State Hillary Clinton and "filthy mouthed wife" (@realDonaldTrump) to describe model Chrissy Teigen to try to shame women with social influence into submission. It is noteworthy, too, that he describes Teigen by her role in relation to a man rather than by her name, which would indicate her individuality. Both Clinton and Teigen, along with millions of women around the world, have worked to empower women by redefining such language. Almost immediately following the accusation of "such a nasty woman," women and girls around the country donned t-shirts and ball caps with the phrase, showing their pride in being "nasty" (Ali). In this context, the term came to describe women who speak truth to power. Although Teigen acknowledges that she had previously been blocked by Trump for trolling him, she shot back defiantly at him with a tweet that read in part: "lol what p— a— b—" (@chrissyteigen). Shortly thereafter, the phrase was trending as a Twitter hashtag (Butler). In this instance, people, particularly women, appreciated Teigen's ability to respond to female shaming with language that Trump himself was recorded using and that is also traditionally used to shame and degrade women. This time, however, it was directed toward a powerful man. This reclamation of power through language is one step women have taken to revise the social gender narrative for a modern context.

Again, Garrison introduces texts for comparison, bringing her argument regarding the reclamation of language into the modern day.

> After four years of being known as "the girl raped by Stanford swimmer Brock Turner," sexual assault survivor Chanel Miller has reclaimed the narrative of her story with the publication of her memoir *Know My Name.* After a Stanford University fraternity party in January 2015, Turner assaulted (with intent to rape) an intoxicated and unconscious Miller behind a dumpster at approximately 1:00 a.m. Some passing students interrupted the act, and Turner was taken by the police after the students restrained him. He was later brought to trial and found guilty. The sympathetic male judge sentenced Turner to only six months in county jail, from which he was released after three months for good behavior. When speaking on television to *60 Minutes* on September 22, 2019, Miller expressed outrage that media coverage during the trial had focused not on what Miller had already lost but on what Turner had to lose if found guilty—his education, his swimming career, his Olympic prospects (Miller). Because Miller remained anonymous during the trial, the media and Turner's lawyers controlled how she was perceived to the world—as a girl who got drunk and put herself into a compromising situation.

Garrison emphasizes the role of language in Miller's telling her story and ceasing to feel ashamed.

> This male-centric characterization of events left Miller feeling ashamed and disempowered. By writing her book and reclaiming her story, Miller took a vital step in healing and trauma management, emphasizing that she now controls the language of her narrative. She is not a girl who deserves what she got, as some would argue. Miller readily acknowledges she deserved a hangover for her actions, but never a rape.

Notice the switching of tenses to indicate events in the past and present. Notice, too, that Garrison returns to the literary present tense in the paragraph that follows.

> Miller's story is all too common in the college partying scene, and the regularity of such attacks contributes to the perpetuation of an environment in which women are made to feel responsible for being attacked and men are free to act as they choose. The awareness of Miller's story and, more importantly, her published story, reframe the narrative around rape culture so that the victims are not further victimized, as women work to educate men so that these attacks stop.

Garrison introduces a final contemporary text for comparison. By citing multiple texts across time, Garrison strengthens her argument.

> Artists and writers such as Chopin, Jackson, Clinton, Teigen, and Miller engage in the gritty work of social reform that cannot be achieved through any other medium because culture cannot change unless the language in which people talk about the culture changes. This socially reformed reality is conceived only from the creativity of intelligent minds that are able both to envision and then to describe the world as it is yet to exist. In this way, artists who work with the medium of language become the prophets.

This conclusion looks to the future, which is a productive rhetorical or persuasive technique to give the audience an idea about what they can take away from this project.

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Garrison follows MLA guidelines to cite her sources.

Discussion Questions

1. How might Gwyn Garrison have used action to introduce her thesis? Dialogue? Is reaction the best choice? Why or why not?
2. What reasoning does Garrison offer to support her thesis?
3. What textual evidence does Garrison offer to support her thesis?
4. How does Garrison connect literary elements—particularly language and character—with real-world events? Explain why you think these connections are valid or not.
5. Are you convinced or unconvinced of the validity of the thesis? Why or why not?

For Reference: "The Storm" by Kate Chopin (1850–1904)



FIGURE 16.5 American author Kate Chopin, 1894 (credit: "KATE O'FLAHERTY BEFORE HER MARRIAGE TO OSCAR CHOPIN" by J.A. Scholten/The State Historical Society of Missouri, Photograph Collection, Public Domain)

> The leaves were so still that even Bibi thought it was going to rain. Bobinôt, who was accustomed to converse on terms of perfect equality with his little son, called the child's attention to certain sombre clouds that were rolling with sinister intention from the west, accompanied by a sullen, threatening roar. They were at Friedheimer's store and decided to remain there till the storm had passed. They sat within the door on two empty kegs. Bibi was four years old and looked very wise.

> "Mama'll be 'fraid, yes," he suggested with blinking eyes.

> "She'll shut the house. Maybe she got Sylvie helpin' her this evenin'," Bobinôt responded reassuringly.

> "No; she ent got Sylvie. Sylvie was helpin' her yistiday," piped Bibi.

> Bobinôt arose and going across to the counter purchased a can of shrimps, of which Calixta was very fond. Then he returned to his perch on the keg and sat stolidly holding the can of shrimps while the storm burst. It shook the wooden store and seemed to be ripping great furrows in the distant field. Bibi laid his little hand on his father's knee and was not afraid.

II

> Calixta, at home, felt no uneasiness for their safety. She sat at a side window sewing furiously on a sewing machine. She was greatly occupied and did not notice the approaching storm. But she felt very warm and often stopped to mop her face on which the perspiration gathered in beads. She unfastened her white sacque at the throat. It began to grow dark, and suddenly realizing the situation she got up hurriedly and went about closing windows and doors.

> Out on the small front gallery she had hung Bobinôt's Sunday clothes to dry and she hastened out to gather them before the rain fell. As she stepped outside, Alcée Laballière rode in at the gate. She had not seen him very often since her marriage, and never alone. She stood there with Bobinôt's coat in her hands, and the big rain drops began to fall. Alcée rode his horse under the shelter of a side projection where the chickens had huddled and there were plows and a harrow piled up in the corner.

> "May I come and wait on your gallery till the storm is over, Calixta?" he asked.

> "Come 'long in, M'sieur Alcée."

> His voice and her own startled her as if from a trance, and she seized Bobinôt's vest. Alcée, mounting to the porch, grabbed the trousers and snatched Bibi's braided jacket that was about to be carried away by a sudden gust of wind. He expressed an intention to remain outside, but it was soon apparent that he might as well have been out in the open: the water beat in upon the boards in driving sheets, and he went inside, closing the door after him. It was even necessary to put something beneath the door to keep the water out.

> "My! what a rain! It's good two years since it rain' like that," exclaimed Calixta as she rolled up a piece of bagging and Alcée helped her to thrust it beneath the crack.

> She was a little fuller of figure than five years before when she married; but she had lost nothing of her vivacity. Her blue eyes still retained their melting quality; and her yellow hair, dishevelled by the wind and rain, kinked more stubbornly than ever about her ears and temples.

> The rain beat upon the low, shingled roof with a force and clatter that threatened to break an entrance and deluge them there. They were in the dining room—the sitting room—the general utility room. Adjoining was her bedroom, with Bibi's couch alongside her own. The door stood open, and the room with its white, monumental bed, its closed shutters, looked dim and mysterious.

> Alcée flung himself into a rocker and Calixta nervously began to gather up from the floor the lengths of a cotton sheet which she had been sewing.

> "If this keeps up, *Dieu sait* if the levees goin' to stan it!" she exclaimed.

> "What have you got to do with the levees?"

> "I got enough to do! An' there's Bobinôt with Bibi out in that storm—if he only didn' left Friedheimer's!"

> "Let us hope, Calixta, that Bobinôt's got sense enough to come in out of a cyclone."

> She went and stood at the window with a greatly disturbed look on her face. She wiped the frame that was clouded with moisture. It was stiflingly hot. Alcée got up and joined her at the window, looking over her shoulder. The rain was coming down in sheets obscuring the view of far-off cabins and enveloping the distant wood in a gray mist. The playing of the lightning was incessant. A bolt struck a tall chinaberry tree at the edge of the field. It filled all visible space with a blinding glare and the crash seemed to invade the very boards they stood upon.

> Calixta put her hands to her eyes, and with a cry, staggered backward. Alcée's arm encircled her, and for an instant he drew her close and spasmodically to him.

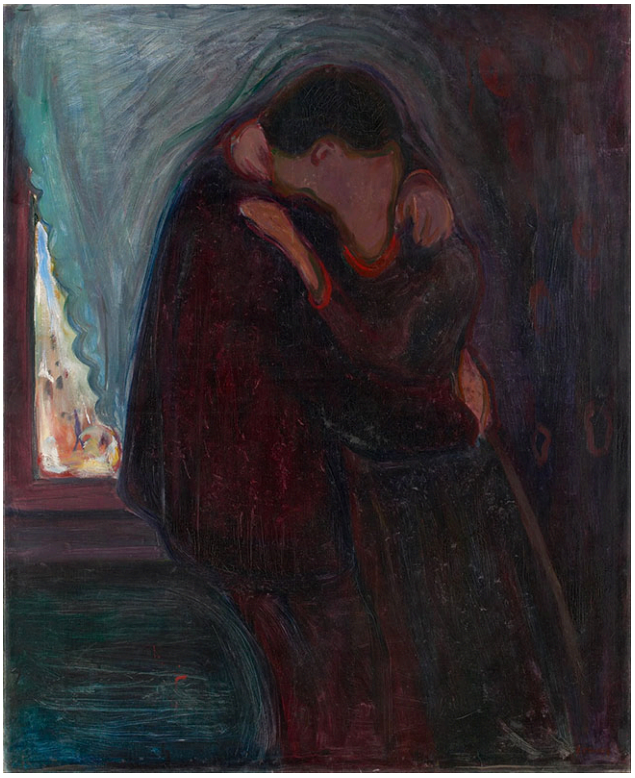


FIGURE 16.6 *The Kiss*, 1887, by Norwegian painter Edvard Munch (1863–1944) (credit: "Edvard Munch - The Kiss" by Google Art Project/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

> "Bonté!" she cried, releasing herself from his encircling arm and retreating from the window, "the house'll go next! If I only knew w'ere Bibi was!" She would not compose herself; she would not be seated. Alcée clasped her shoulders and looked into her face. The contact of her warm, palpitating body when he had unthinkingly drawn her into his arms, had aroused all the old-time infatuation and desire for her flesh.

> "Calixta," he said, "don't be frightened. Nothing can happen. The house is too low to be struck, with so many tall trees standing about. There! Aren't you going to be quiet? say, aren't you?" He pushed her hair back from her face that was warm and steaming. Her lips were as red and moist as pomegranate seeds. Her white neck and a glimpse of her full, firm bosom disturbed him powerfully. As she glanced up at him the fear in her liquid blue eyes had given place to a drowsy gleam that unconsciously betrayed a sensuous desire. He looked down into her eyes and there was nothing for him to do but to gather her lips in a kiss. It reminded him of Assumption.

> "Do you remember—in Assumption, Calixta?" he asked in a low voice broken by passion. Oh! she remembered; for in Assumption he had kissed her and kissed her; until his senses would well nigh fail, and to save her he would resort to a desperate flight. If she was not an immaculate dove in those days, she was still inviolate; a passionate creature whose very defenselessness had made her defense, against which his honor forbade him to prevail. Now—well, now—her lips seemed in a manner free to be tasted, as well as her round, white throat and her whiter breasts.

> They did not heed the crashing torrents, and the roar of the elements made her laugh as she lay in his arms. She was a revelation in that dim, mysterious chamber; as white as the couch she lay upon. Her firm, elastic flesh that was knowing for the first time its birthright, was like a creamy lily that the sun invites to contribute its breath and perfume to the undying life of the world. The generous abundance of her passion, without guile or trickery, was like a white flame which penetrated and found response in depths of his own sensuous nature that had never yet been reached.

> When he touched her breasts they gave themselves up in quivering ecstasy, inviting his lips. Her mouth was a fountain of delight. And when he possessed her, they seemed to swoon together at the very borderland of life's mystery.

> He stayed cushioned upon her, breathless, dazed, enervated, with his heart beating like a hammer upon her. With one hand she clasped his head, her lips lightly touching his forehead. The other hand stroked with a soothing rhythm his muscular shoulders.

> The growl of the thunder was distant and passing away. The rain beat softly upon the shingles, inviting them to drowsiness and sleep. But they dared not yield.

> The rain was over; and the sun was turning the glistening green world into a palace of gems. Calixta, on the gallery, watched Alcée ride away. He turned and smiled at her with a beaming face; and she lifted her pretty chin in the air and laughed aloud.

III

> Bobinôt and Bibi, trudging home, stopped without at the cistern to make themselves presentable.

> "My! Bibi, w'at will yo' mama say! You ought to be ashame'. You oughta' put on those good pants. Look at 'em! An' that mud on yo' collar! How you got that mud on yo' collar, Bibi? I never saw such a boy!" Bibi was the picture of pathetic resignation. Bobinôt was the embodiment of serious solicitude as he strove to remove from his own person and his son's the signs of their tramp over heavy roads and through wet fields. He scraped the mud off Bibi's bare legs and feet with a stick and carefully removed all traces from his heavy brogans. Then, prepared for the worst—the meeting with an over-scrupulous housewife, they entered cautiously at the backdoor.

> Calixta was preparing supper. She had set the table and was dripping coffee at the hearth. She sprang up as they came in.

> "Oh, Bobinôt! You back! My! but I was uneasy. W'ere you been during the rain? An' Bibi? he ain't wet? he ain't hurt?" She had clasped Bibi and was kissing him effusively. Bobinôt's explanations and apologies which he had been composing all along the way, died on his lips as Calixta felt him to see if he were dry, and seemed to express nothing but satisfaction at their safe return.

> "I brought you some shrimps, Calixta," offered Bobinôt, hauling the can from his ample side pocket and laying it on the table.

> "Shrimps! Oh, Bobinôt! you too good fo' anything!" and she gave him a smacking kiss on the cheek that resounded, "*J'vous réponds*, we'll have a feas' to-night! umph-umph!"

> Bobinôt and Bibi began to relax and enjoy themselves, and when the three seated themselves at table they laughed much and so loud that anyone might have heard them as far away as Laballière's.

IV

> Alcée Laballière wrote to his wife, Clarisse, that night. It was a loving letter, full of tender solicitude. He told her not to hurry back, but if she and the babies liked it at Biloxi, to stay a month longer. He was getting on nicely; and though he missed them, he was willing to bear the separation a while longer—realizing that their health and pleasure were the first things to be considered.

V

> As for Clarisse, she was charmed upon receiving her husband's letter. She and the babies were doing well. The society was agreeable; many of her old friends and acquaintances were at the bay. And the first free breath since her marriage seemed to restore the pleasant liberty of her maiden days. Devoted as she was to her husband, their intimate conjugal life was something which she was more than willing to forego for a while. So the storm passed and everyone was happy.

16.5 Writing Process: Thinking Critically About Text

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Develop a writing project focused on textual analysis.
- Complete the stages of the writing process, including generating ideas, drafting, reviewing, revising, rewriting, and editing.
- Integrate the writer's ideas with ideas of others.
- Collaborate in the peer review process.

When analyzing a text, writers usually focus on the content of the text itself and deliberately leave themselves in the background, minimizing personal presence and bias. To write this way, they avoid first-person pronouns and value judgments. In reality, of course, writers do reveal their presence by the choices they make: what they include, what they exclude, and what they emphasize. Although your own subjectivity and situation will likely affect your inferences and judgments, recognizing these potential biases will help you keep the focus on your subject and off yourself.

Summary of Assignment

Write an analytical essay about a short story or another short text of your choice, either fiction or literary nonfiction. If desired, you may choose "The Storm" by Kate Chopin, reprinted above. Consider the author's form and organization, tone, or stylistic choices, including diction and sensory or figurative language. You might also consider the historical or social context, the theme, the character development, or the relation between setting and plot or characterization. If you are free to choose your own text and topic, consider the following approaches:

- Analyze the literary components mentioned and focus your essay on their significance in the work.
- Like student author Gwyn Garrison, choose one or several components and examine how different authors use them and how they relate to broader contexts.

Convincing textual analysis essays usually include the following information:

- overview of the text, identifying author, title, and genre
- very brief summary
- description of the text's form and structure
- explanation of the author's point of view

- summary of the social, historical, or cultural context in which the work was written
- assertion or thesis about what the text means: your main task as an analyst

When writing about a novel or short story, explain how the main elements function:

- narrator (who tells the story)
- plot (what happens in the story)
- one or more characters (who are acting or being acted upon)
- setting (when and where things are happening)
- theme (the meaning of the story)

Keep in mind that the author who writes the story is different from the narrator and invented characters in it. Keep in mind, too, that what happens in the story—the plot—is different from the meaning of the story—the theme. Understanding what happens will help you discover what the text means.

The elements (https://openstax.org/r/elements) of literary or narrative nonfiction are similar to those of a fictional story *except* that everything in the text is supposed to have really happened. For this reason, the author and the narrator of the story may be one and the same. Informational nonfiction—essays, reports, and textbook chapters—is also meant to be believed; here, however, ideas and arguments must be strong and well supported to be convincing. When analyzing nonfiction, pay special attention to the author's thesis or claim and to how it is supported through reasoning and evidence. Also note interesting or unusual tone, style, form, or voice.

Another Lens 1. In writing from a personal or subjective viewpoint, the writer and their beliefs and experiences are necessarily part of your analysis and may need to be expressed and examined. For example, you may write subjectively and compare and contrast your situation with that of the author or a character. You might explain how your personal background causes you to read the text in a particular way that is meaningful to you. If you choose this option, be sure to analyze the text as you would for a more objective analysis before focusing on your personal views.

Another Lens 2. A leading contemporary example of narrative nonfiction writing is Jon Krakauer's (b. 1954) *Into the Wild* (https://openstax.org/r/Into-the-Wild), the story of Chris McCandless (1968– c. 1992), a young college graduate who lived at subsistence level in the backwoods of Alaska for 113 days. The text is somewhat similar thematically to Henry David Thoreau's (1817–1862) *Walden* (1854), written more than a century earlier and discussed later in this section. Both are about dropping out of society to create a meaningful life. After reading the excerpt of *Into the Wild* linked above, you may choose to write a textual analysis of it either on its own or in light of the sample analysis of Thoreau's writings later in this section. Consider comparing and contrasting McCandless's situation with Thoreau's life in Walden and how Krakauer and Thoreau use various literary elements in their writing. Topics for analysis might be setting, character traits, motives, cultural communities, historical context, and attitudes toward life and society.

Quick Launch: Start with Your Thesis

For textual analysis, your thesis should be a clear, concise statement that identifies your analytical stance on which readers will expect you to elaborate.

Develop a working thesis

A working thesis is referred to as such because the thesis is subject to revision. You may have to revisit it later in the writing process, for it is almost impossible to craft a thesis without having analyzed some of the text first. Your thesis, therefore, will come from the element(s) you choose to analyze, such as the following:

- an aspect or several aspects of form and structure and their significance
- social, historical, or cultural context in which the text was written and its significance
- style elements such as diction, imagery, or figurative language and their significance

- aspects of characters, plot, or setting
- overall theme of a single work or more than one work
- comparison or contrast of elements within one or more works
- relation to issues outside the text

To develop a working thesis, use the formula shown in Table 16.1, basing your answers on one of the bulleted items listed above.

What are you doing? + Why are you doing it?
What are you doing? Analyzing Kate Chopin's short story "The Storm"
+
Why are you doing it? "To argue that…"
=
In the short story "The Storm," author Kate Chopin uses linguistic variety to add to the character development.

TABLE 16.1

You can also start with an analytical question: *For what reason(s) does Chopin use linguistic variety?* Your initial answer might yield the thesis above. Or you can ask another analytical question, such as this one: *In what ways do the plot and setting of "The Storm" reinforce its theme?*

Drafting: Explore Possible Areas of Analysis for Fiction: Approach 1

Analytical essays (https://openstax.org/r/Analytical-essays) begin by answering basic questions: *What genre is this text—poem, play, story, biography, memoir, essay? What is its title? Who is the author? When was it published?*

Identify and Summarize the Text

In addition to the basic questions, analytical essays provide a brief summary of the plot or main idea. Summarize briefly, logically, and objectively to provide a background for what you plan to say about the text. This information may be incorporated into the introduction or may follow it.

Explain the Form and Organization

To analyze the organizational structure of a text, ask: *How is it put together? Why does the author start here and end there? Why does the author sequence information in this order? What connects the text from start to finish?* For example, by repeating words, ideas, and images, writers call attention to these elements and indicate that they are important to the meaning of the text. No matter what the text, some principle or plan holds it together and gives it structure. Fiction and nonfiction texts that tell stories are often, but not always, organized as a sequence of events in chronological order. Poems may have formal structures or other organizational elements. Other texts may alternate between explanations and examples or between first-person and third-person narrative. You will have to decide which aspects of the text's form and organization are most important for your analysis.

For example, this student analyzes the point of view of Gwendolyn Brooks's poem "We Real Cool (https://openstax.org/r/We-Real-Cool).".

> Gwendolyn Brooks writes "We Real Cool" (1963) from the point of view of members of a street gang who speak as one voice. The boys have dropped out of school to spend their lives hanging around pool halls—in this case "The Golden Shovel." These guys speak in slangy lingo, such as "Strike straight," that reveals their need for a melded identity in their rebellious attitude toward life. The plural speaker in the poem, "We," celebrates what adults might call adolescent hedonism—but the speaker, feeling powerful in the group identity, makes a conscious choice for a short, intense life over a long, safe, and dull existence.

Place the Work in Context

To analyze the context of a text, ask: *What circumstances (historical, social, political, biographical) produced this text? How does this text compare or contrast with another by the same author or with a similar work by a different author?* No text exists in isolation. Each was created by a particular author in a particular place at a particular time. Describing this context provides readers with important background information and indicates which conditions you think were most influential.

For example, this student analyzes the social context of Gwendolyn Brooks's poem "We Real Cool."

> From society's viewpoint, the boys are nothing but misfits—refusing to work, leading violent lives, breaking laws, and confronting police. However, these boys live in a society that is dangerous for Black men, who often die at the hands of police even when they are doing the right thing. The boys are hopeless, recognizing no future but death, regardless of their actions, and thus "Die soon."

Explain the Theme of the Text

To analyze the theme of a text, determine the implied theme in fiction, poetry, and narrative nonfiction. One purpose for writing a textual analysis is to point out the theme. Ask yourself: *So what? What is this text really about? What do I think the author is trying to say by writing this text? What problems, puzzles, or ideas are most interesting? In what ways do the characters change between the beginning and end of the text?* Good ideas for a thesis arise from material in which the meaning is not obviously stated.

For example, this student analyzes one theme of Gwendolyn Brooks's poem "We Real Cool."

> For the "Seven at the Golden Shovel," companionship is everything. For many teenagers, fitting in or conforming to a group identity is more important than developing an individual identity. Brooks expresses this theme through the poem's point of view, the plural "We" repeated at the end of each line.

Analyze Stylistic Choices

To analyze stylistic choices, examine the details of the text. Ask yourself: *Why does the author use this word or phrase instead of a synonym for it? In what ways does this word or phrase relate to other words or phrases? In what ways do the author's figurative comparisons affect the meaning or tone of the text? In what ways does use of sensory language (imagery) affect the meaning or tone of the text? In what ways does this element represent more than itself? In what ways does the author use sound or rhythm to support meaning?*

For example, this student analyzes the diction of Gwendolyn Brooks's poem "We Real Cool."

> Brooks chooses the word *cool* to open the poem and build the first rhyme. Being cool is the code by which the boys live. However, the word *cool* also suggests the idiom "to be placed 'on ice,'" a term that suggests a delay. The boys live in a state of arrested development, anticipating early deaths. In addition, the term *to ice* someone means "to kill," another reference to the death imagery at poem's end. The boys are not suggesting suicide; they expect to be killed by members of society who find them threatening.

Support Your Analysis

Analytical interpretations (https://openstax.org/r/Analytical) are built around evidence from the text itself.

You'll note the quotations in the examples above. Summarize larger ideas in your own language to conserve space. Paraphrase more specific ideas, also in your own words, and quote directly to feature the author's diction. See Editing Focus: Paragraphs and Transitions and Writing Process: Integrating Research for more information about summarizing, paraphrasing, and quoting directly. If you include outside information for support, comparison, or contrast, document the sources carefully: MLA Documentation and Format.

Use a graphic organizer such as Table 16.2 to gather ideas for drafting.

Genre	Analysis	Your Ideas
If you've chosen to analyze poetry,	Consider the role of... Word choice (imagery) Structure of lines and stanzas Sound (meter, rhyme, rhythm) Figurative language (simile, metaphor, personification)	Why does the author... ? What is the effect on meaning, tone, or audience?
If you've chosen to analyze drama,	Consider the role of... Characters and dialogue Setting Plot and conflict Theme Structure of acts, scenes, and stage directions	Why does the author... ? What is the effect on meaning, tone, or audience?
If you've chosen to analyze fiction or narrative nonfiction,	Consider the role of... Characters (narrator or author in narrative nonfiction) Setting Plot (or real events in narrative nonfiction) and conflict Theme Diction Structure (chronology, flashback or forward, foreshadowing, chapters)	Why does the author... ? What is the effect on meaning, tone, or audience?

TABLE 16.2 Ideas for drafting a textual analysis essay

Drafting: Explore Possible Areas of Analysis for Literary Nonfiction: Approach 2

Although similar to fiction, narrative or literary nonfiction has a basic orientation toward exposition: relating real events in a creative way rather than inventing fictional events and characters. In reading and analyzing expository prose, you also may encounter literary language, narrative structure, characters, setting, theme, and plot development, depending on the type of prose. Therefore, your approach to analyzing nonfiction will call on many of the same strategies you use to analyze fiction. Two basic differences, however, are that literary nonfiction may have less dialogue, depending on the genre, and that the author and narrator may be the same. In other words, no intermediary or artistic filter may exist between the author and the work. The nonfiction author is assumed to be speaking a truth, which may be serious, comic, controversial, or neutral. Fictional characters, on the other hand, are creations of an author's mind; they think and speak as they were created to do.

Planning the Essay

In writing your essay, you will need to present the same kinds of text evidence as you would when analyzing fiction to give credibility to your claims and to support your thesis. And you'll need to keep in mind the rhetorical situation—purpose, audience, stance, context, and culture—as well, for it remains the building block of an effective analysis. As in most academic essays, body paragraphs refer to the thesis through topic sentences and move consistently toward supporting it before you finally arrive at a convincing conclusion that has grown out of the analysis. In nonfiction, because you assume you are dealing with a truthful explanation of facts and views, your task should be to give a new view and understanding of something that already may be familiar to readers. In writing your analysis, consider the following plan:

- Begin your analysis of nonfiction with an introductory overview in which you include the work's genre, title, author, and publication date.
- Identify the literary point of view, if relevant: first person—*I* or plural *we*—or third-person—*he, she*, or *they*.
- Continue with a brief summary of the work, and place it in context: the work's social, historical, and cultural background will help readers follow your points about its theme.
- Present your thesis near the end of the introduction. It should be argumentative, in an academic sense, so that you can "prove" your points.
- Support your thesis with well-elaborated body paragraphs, as you do with all thesis-based writing. Include paraphrases, summaries, and quotations from the text (and outside sources, if you do research for the assignment). Body paragraphs support the topic sentences, which in turn support the thesis.
- Conclude by restating your thesis (using different words and an appropriate transition). Add a general statement about the work and its significance or, if applicable, its relation to culture, history, current events, art, or anything else outside it.

Use the applicable suggestions in Table 16.3 in planning your essay (https://openstax.org/r/planning):

Title	
Introduction	Title(s), author(s), publication date(s), historical context, summary, thesis
Body paragraphs (as many as needed; minimum of 3)	Transition Claims and supporting evidence: your ideas, paraphrases and/or quotations from text
Counterclaim (if any)	Addressing opposing or negative ideas
Conclusion	Restatement of thesis, broader generalization

TABLE 16.3 Literary nonfiction planner

Literary Nonfiction Model

A frequent theme in literary nonfiction is the examination of alternative ways of living, often solitary and away from society, and finding truth in individualism and self-sufficiency. Although most people live in social groups and willingly accept the identity and security that communities offer, dropping out and going it alone have long been a part of emotional as well as physical life for some.

You have the option to analyze the nonfiction accounts of writers exploring solitary human behavior in American life. If you select **Another Lens 2**, you will read an excerpt from the story of Chris McCandless (1968–c. 1992), who chose a brief and uncomfortable solitary existence in Alaska. Or you can read the following section dealing with the works of Henry David Thoreau, the American philosopher and author who dropped out of society temporarily, largely because of his strong opposition to government policies he believed to be morally wrong and because of his refusal to conform to social practices and expectations he found objectionable.

Introduction

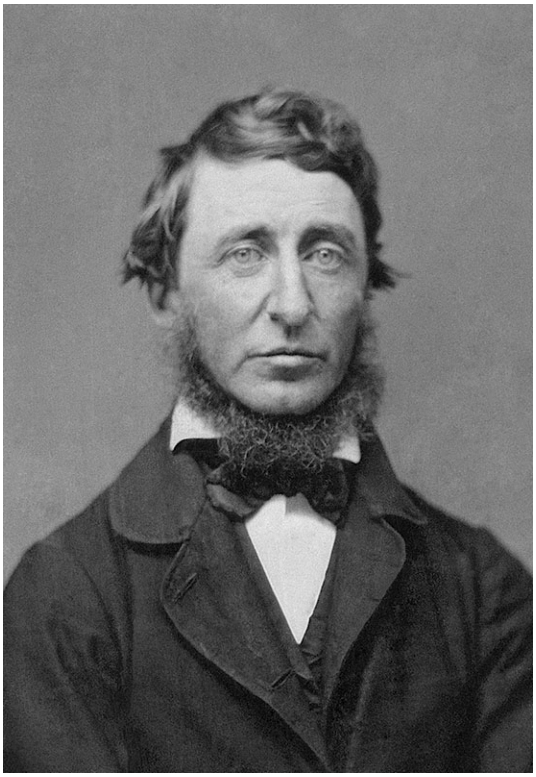


FIGURE 16.7 Henry David Thoreau, American naturalist, philosopher, and writer (credit: "Henry David Thoreau - Restored – greyscale" by Benjamin Maxham [1821–1899]/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

Henry David Thoreau (1817–1862) is best known as a thinker and writer on nature, as reflected in his two famous works, the highly influential Civil Disobedience (https://openstax.org/r/Civil-Disobedience) (1849) and *Walden; or, Life in the Woods* (1854). Both works celebrate individual freedoms: the right to protest against what one believes is morally or ethically wrong and the choice to live as one believes. In describing his life over a period of precisely two years, two months, and two days in a 10-by-15-foot cabin he built on Walden Pond, 20 miles northwest of Boston near Concord, Massachusetts, Thoreau wrote:

> I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately [carefully, unhurried], to front [confront] only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived. I did not wish to live what was not life, living is so dear; nor did I wish to practise resignation, unless it was quite necessary. I wanted to live deep and suck out all the marrow of life.

Thoreau's insistence on standing by his principles and on living a simple life by choice are two abiding themes in his work. Even before the physical move to Walden, Thoreau had refused to pay his poll tax (granting him the right to vote) for a number of years because he strongly objected to the government's use of his money to support enslavement and the war with Mexico. He went peacefully to jail as a result, until he was bailed out (the next day). In "Civil Disobedience," Thoreau advocates for more individual freedom and for individuals to defy unjust laws in nonviolent ways. His writings on "passive resistance" inspired the thoughts and actions of influential figures such as Indian leader Mohandas Gandhi (1869–1948), American religious and civil rights leader Martin Luther King, Jr. (1929–1968), and other leaders of nonviolent liberation movements. In *Walden*, Thoreau describes and advocates for a simple life in which a person breaks with society when they feel the need to express their individualism, often based on ideas others do not share.

These themes are the focus of analysis in the following excerpts from an essay by student Alex Jones for a first-year composition class.

> **The Two Freedoms of Henry David Thoreau by Alex Jones**

> Henry David Thoreau led millions of people throughout the world to think of individual freedom in new ways. During his lifetime he attempted to live free of unjust governmental restraints as well as conventional social expectations. In his 1849 political essay "On the Duty of Civil Disobedience," he makes his strongest case against governmental interference in the lives of citizens. In his 1854 book *Walden; or Life in the Woods*, he makes the case for actually living free, as he did in his own life, from social conventions and expectations.

The title clearly identifies Thoreau and sets the expectation that two aspects or definitions of freedom will be discussed in two different works. Alex Jones wants readers to know that millions of people worldwide figure in Thoreau's legacy. He gives the examples of "unjust governmental restraints" and "conventional social expectations" as the parts of social life Thoreau rejected, thus limiting the scope of the analysis and preparing for the body of the essay.

Jones notes the titles and publication dates of both works and immediately moves ahead to analyze the two works, "Civil Disobedience" first. He will show how this political statement leads to the narrative of Walden, the actual story of a man's life in temporary exile.

> Thoreau opens "Civil Disobedience" with his statement "that government is best which governs not at all."

The analysis moves immediately to the first work to be discussed and features the memorable quotation regarding a government that does not govern. The statement may seem contradictory, but for Thoreau it is a direct statement in that someone who allows himself to be imprisoned will find freedom by distancing himself from all others to prove his point.

> He argues that a government should allow its people to be as free as possible while providing for their needs without interfering in daily life. In other words, in daily life a person attends to the business of eating, sleeping, and earning a living and not dealing in any noticeable way with an entity called "a government."

Jones repeats "in daily life" to give a rhythm to his own prose and to emphasize the importance to Thoreau of daily activities that are simple and meaningful. The word government is repeated for emphasis as the negative subject of this essay—in literary terms, a powerful and constant antagonist that constrains and disempowers.

> Because Thoreau did not want his freedom overshadowed by government regulations, he tried to ignore them. However, the American government of 1845 would not let him. He was arrested and put in the Concord jail for failing to pay his poll tax, a tax he believed unjust because it supported the government's war with Mexico as well as the immoral institution of slavery. Instead of protesting his arrest, he celebrated it and explained its meaning by writing "Civil Disobedience," one of the most famous English-language essays ever written. In it, he argues persuasively, "Under a government which imprisons any unjustly, the true place for a just man is also a prison" (230). Thus, the idea of passive resistance—and accepting unjust arrest to make a point—was formed, a doctrine that advocated protest against the government by nonviolent means:
>
> > How does it become a man to behave toward this American government today? I answer that he cannot without disgrace be associated with it. I cannot for an instant recognize that political organization as my government which is the slave's government also. (224)

Jones strengthens his own writing by calling the essay one of the most famous works ever written. This is not an ordinary technique in textual analysis, but when done for emphasis, it helps the analysis gain power. Using "instead of protesting" at the start of his sentence is another example of strong contrast and linkage.

> For nearly 200 years, Thoreau's formulation of passive resistance has been a part of the human struggle for freedom. In fact, it changed the world by inspiring the resistance movements led by Mohandas Gandhi and Martin Luther King, Jr.

The total effect is to make Jones's analytical essay more important for readers, as Thoreau's writings have indeed changed the world despite being written humbly as the voice of one man's conscience and isolation in his own freedom.

> Thoreau also wanted to be free from the everyday pressures to conform to society's expectations.

Jones transitions from the first short work to the different and equally famous nonfiction narrative Walden, moving smoothly from one freedom to the next with the transition "also wanted." This second analysis of freedom is the second part of the essay's thesis.

> He believed in doing and possessing only the essential things in life. To demonstrate his case, in 1845, he moved to the outskirts of Concord, Massachusetts, and lived by himself for just over two years in a cabin he built at Walden Pond. Thoreau wrote *Walden* to explain the value of living simply, far removed from the unnecessary complexity of society: "simplicity, simplicity, simplicity! I say, let your affairs be as two or three, and not a hundred or a thousand" (66). At Walden, he lived as much as possible by this statement, building his own house and furniture, growing his own food, bartering for simple necessities, and attending to his own business rather than seeking employment from others.

Jones uses textual evidence to support his claim. He summarizes Thoreau's activities at Walden and quotes Thoreau as evidence to reinforce the freedom of mind that simple living allows.



FIGURE 16.8 Setting for Thoreau's cabin at Walden Pond near Concord (credit: "Site of Thoreau's Hut, Concord, Mass" by Detroit Publishing Company/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

> Living at Walden Pond gave Thoreau the chance to formulate many of his ideas about living an unencumbered, economical life. At Walden, he lived simply to "front only the essential facts of life" (66) and to center his thoughts on "living" instead of on unnecessary details of mere livelihood. He developed survival skills that freed him from the constraints of city dwellers whose lives depended upon a web of material things and services provided by others. He preferred to "take rank hold on life and spend my day more as animals do" (117).

Jones uses the poetic language of high rhetoric directly from Thoreau. The body of the essay gives specific evidence of how Thoreau ate, built, read, and provided for his needs, cutting away all but the essential man in the two settings of his life.

> While living at Walden Pond, Thoreau was free to occupy his time in any way that pleased him, which for him meant mostly writing and tending his bean patch. The details of his gardening appear frequently, as he concentrated on it during his time there. He wasn't troubled by a boss hounding him with deadlines or a wife and children who needed his attention. His neighbors accused him of being selfish and did not understand that he sought most of all "to live deliberately" (66), as he felt all people should learn to do.

> Then, as now, most people had more responsibilities than Thoreau had and could not just pack up their belongings and go live in the woods—if they could find free woods to live in. Today, people are intrigued to read about Thoreau's experiences and are inspired by his thoughts, but few people can actually live or do as he suggests. The idea of life without cell phones or Internet seems inconceivable, even if one grows one's own food and lives mostly off the grid.

The next-to-last paragraph recognizes what could be a counterclaim: not everyone in contemporary times would view living alone for two years as a pleasure. Rather, they might see it as a different kind of prison, perhaps even a dangerous one. Indeed, such deprivation has less appeal these days, and people who do go off by themselves may be seen to have questionable motives.

> The theme of exploring how a man lives in or outside governmental control is clear in the choices he must make to define himself as a free person. Nevertheless, practical or not, Thoreau's writings about freedom from government and society have inspired countless people to reassess how they live their lives. Though unable to live as Thoreau advocated, readers everywhere remain inspired by his ideals and his belief in the two freedoms.

Jones concludes by emphasizing the strength of Thoreau's ideas—his two freedoms—and the influence they have had in the world.

Review the Essay

After reading Alex Jones's essay, complete the following sentences to review his work:

- He identifies and summarizes the content by _____.
- He describes the form and structure of Thoreau's works when _____.
- He places Thoreau and his works in context by _____.
- He clearly states his own theme in reading Thoreau, which is _____.
- He indicates Thoreau's unusual language at times, such as _____.
- He gives supporting evidence for his points, such as _____.
- He includes a visual to _____.
- He concludes with a balanced and convincing viewpoint by _____.



FIGURE 16.9 Contemporary replica of Thoreau's cabin and statue of Thoreau (credit: "Walden pond - Thoreau's house" by Luigi Franchini/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

For Reference: excerpt from *Walden (https://openstax.org/r/Civil-Disobedience)* by Henry David Thoreau *from* "Where I Lived and What I Lived For"

> When first I took up my abode in the woods, that is, began to spend my nights as well as days there, which, by accident, was on Independence Day, or the Fourth of July, 1845, my house was not finished for winter, but was merely a defense against the rain, without plastering or chimney, the walls being of rough, weather-stained boards, with wide chinks, which made it cool at night. The upright white hewn studs and freshly planed door and window casings gave it a clean and airy look, especially in the morning, when its timbers were saturated with dew, so that I fancied that by noon some sweet gum would exude from them. To my imagination it retained throughout the day more or less of this auroral character, reminding me of a certain house on a mountain which I had visited the year before. This was an airy and unplastered cabin, fit to entertain a travelling god, and where a goddess might trail her garments. The winds which passed over my dwelling were such as sweep over the ridges of mountains, bearing the broken strains, or celestial parts only, of terrestrial music....

> The only house I had been the owner of before, if I except a boat, was a tent, which I used occasionally when making excursions in the summer, and this is still rolled up in my garret; but the boat, after passing from hand to hand, has gone down the stream of time. With this more substantial shelter about me, I had made some progress toward settling in the world. This frame, so slightly clad, was a sort of crystallization around me, and reacted on the builder. It was suggestive somewhat as a picture in outlines. I did not need to go outdoors to take the air, for the atmosphere within had lost none of its freshness. It was not so much within doors as behind a door where I sat, even in the rainiest weather. The Harivansa [important Sanskrit text] says, "An abode without birds is like a meat without seasoning." Such was not my abode, for I found myself suddenly neighbor to the birds; not by having imprisoned one, but having caged myself near them....

> For the first week, whenever I looked out on the pond it impressed me like a tarn high up on the side of a mountain, its bottom far above the surface of other lakes, and, as the sun arose, I saw it throwing off its nightly clothing of mist, and here and there, by degrees, its soft ripples or its smooth reflecting surface was revealed, while the mists, like ghosts, were stealthily withdrawing in every direction into the woods, as at the breaking up of some nocturnal conventicle. The very dew seemed to hang upon the trees later into the day than usual, as on the sides of mountains.

> This small lake was of most value as a neighbor in the intervals of a gentle rain storm in August, when, both air and water being perfectly still, but the sky overcast, mid-afternoon had all the serenity of evening, and the wood-thrush sang around, and was heard from shore to shore. A lake like this is never smoother than at such a time; and the clear portion of the air above it being shallow and darkened by clouds, the water, full of light and reflections, becomes a lower heaven itself so much the more important. From a hill top nearby, where the wood had been recently cut off, there was a pleasing vista southward across the pond, through a wide indentation in the hills which form the shore there, where their opposite sides sloping toward each other suggested a stream flowing out in that direction through a wooded valley, but stream there was none. That way I looked between and over the near green hills to some distant and higher ones in the horizon, tinged with blue. Indeed, by standing on tiptoe I could catch a glimpse of some of the peaks of the still bluer and more distant mountain ranges in the north-west, those true-blue coins from heaven's own mint, and also of some portion of the village. But in other directions, even from this point, I could not see over or beyond the woods which surrounded me. It is well to have some water in your neighborhood, to give buoyancy to and float the earth. One value even of the smallest well is, that when you look into it you see that earth is not continent but insular. This is as important as that it keeps butter cool. When I looked across the pond from this peak toward the Sudbury meadows, which in time of flood I distinguished elevated perhaps by a mirage in their seething valley, like a coin in a basin, all the earth beyond the pond appeared like a thin crust insulated and floated even by this small sheet of interverting water, and I was reminded that this on which I dwelt was but *dry land*.

> We must learn to reawaken and keep ourselves awake, not by mechanical aids, but by an infinite expectation of the dawn, which does not forsake us in our soundest sleep. I know of no more encouraging fact than the unquestionable ability of man to elevate his life by a conscious endeavor. It is something to be able to paint a particular picture, or to carve a statue, and so to make a few objects beautiful; but it is far more glorious to carve and paint the very atmosphere and medium through which we look, which morally we can do. To affect the quality of the day, that is the highest of arts. Every man is tasked to make his life, even in its details, worthy of the contemplation of his most elevated and critical hour. If we refused, or rather used up, such paltry information as we get, the oracles would distinctly inform us how this might be done.

> I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived. I did not wish to live what was not life, living is so dear; nor did I wish to practise resignation, unless it was quite necessary. I wanted to live deep and suck out all the marrow of life, to live so sturdily and Spartan-like as to put to rout all that was not life, to cut a broad swath and shave close, to drive life into a corner, and reduce it to its lowest terms, and, if it proved to be mean, why then to get the whole and genuine meanness of it, and publish its meanness to the world; or if it were sublime, to know it by experience, and be able to give a true account of it in my next excursion. For most men, it appears to me, are in a strange uncertainty about it, whether it is of the devil or of God, and have *somewhat hastily* concluded that it is the chief end of man here to "glorify God and enjoy him forever."

> Still we live meanly, like ants; though the fable tells us that we were long ago changed into men; like pygmies we fight with cranes; it is error upon error, and clout upon clout, and our best virtue has for its occasion a superfluous and evitable wretchedness. Our life is frittered away by detail. An honest man has hardly need to count more than his ten fingers, or in extreme cases he may add his ten toes, and lump the rest. Simplicity, simplicity, simplicity! I say, let your affairs be as two or three, and not a hundred or a thousand; instead of a million count half a dozen, and keep your accounts on your thumb nail. In the midst of this chopping sea of civilized life, such are the clouds and storms and quicksands and thousand-and-one items to be allowed for, that a man has to live, if he would not founder and go to the bottom and not make his port at all, by dead reckoning, and he must be a great calculator indeed who succeeds. Simplify, simplify. Instead of three meals a day, if it be necessary eat but one; instead of a hundred dishes...

> Why should we live with such... waste of life? We are determined to be starved before we are hungry. Men say that a stitch in time saves nine, and so they take a thousand stitches to-day to save nine to-morrow.

Peer Review:

After you have completed your first draft, exchange essays with a partner for peer review. Look at the questions you answered to address the essay about Thoreau. Then, to provide helpful feedback, answer these questions about your peer's draft.

1. Does the introduction include the author, title of the work, publication date, historical context, and a brief summary?
2. What is your peer's main claim, or thesis? Is it clearly stated? If not, how might your peer clarify it?
3. Is the thesis effectively supported throughout the essay? How does each paragraph support the thesis? What evidence does each contain? Has the writer included direct quotations, paraphrases, and summary as relevant and convincing support? Is there enough information to sustain the writer's claims? How might the author improve their support? In working on this section, go through each body paragraph separately for these criteria.
4. Does the analysis address counterclaims? If not, how might the writer include them?
5. Which sentence or sentences restate the thesis? If a restatement is not there, what might the writer include?

Revising:

Once you have feedback from a peer, consider their suggestions. Read all comments, and think carefully before making changes.

- **Use your discretion**. Sometimes writers do not agree with their peers' suggestions; indeed, authors do not always revise everything suggested by editors. However, it is important to clarify what might have prompted a response from a peer, such as "This seems like more of an unsupported opinion than text-based evidence." Here you might consider including a source citation either from the text or from an outside resource, or consider further explaining your claim. However, if you think your peer reviewer

misinterpreted or read your claim superficially, do not revise it. At all times, though, maintain ownership. It is your paper; you are the ultimate judge of whether the ideas in it represent you and your views. Never include someone else's idea in your paper if you do not understand it or believe it. Whether or not you decide to revise, be sure to read and consider all suggestions carefully.

- **Focus on global suggestions first.** Global feedback applies to your entire paper. You may have to revise your topic or thesis so that your paper meets assigned guidelines or does what it should. It is important to revise global feedback first, for these revisions might necessitate changes in content and organization, among other things.
- **Complete a close revision.** Check your paper to revise for clarity at the sentence level, and double-check citations, if you have them, for accuracy and style.

In Chapter 16, you have learned about the revision process, including how to evaluate suggestions for revision from peer review. In this activity, evaluate each revision suggestion for specificity. A specific suggestion is helpful and easy to implement. A general suggestion is not helpful and should be ignored unless you can go back and ask the reviewer to provide more details. Based on your evaluation, look at each revision suggestion and decide whether to implement or to ignore.

Access multimedia content (http://openstax.org/books/writing-guide/pages/16-5-writing-process-thinking-critically-about-text)

Student Revision Model

Below is a paragraph from the first draft of Gwyn Garrison's paper. It was reviewed by a peer, who made the suggestions indicated. First, read the draft. Next, read the reviewer's suggestions and consider whether you would accept or reject each one. Then, read the paragraph as it appears in the final version. After each suggestion, consider why you think Gwyn Garrison accepted or rejected the reviewer's comment.

Original Draft

> When Calixta acts outside of societal norms, she discovers the freedom of self-expression and passion. Chopin's diction evokes a spiritual transcendence that allows Calixta to exist momentarily outside social norms that exist only in the physical plane of existence: "when he possessed her, they seemed to swoon at the very borderland of life's mystery." The affair becomes a vehicle that allows Calixta to get to a place of true self-expression. The storm, an aspect of nature or the natural world, acts as the catalyst in Calixta's natural self-realization of womanhood. The storm breaks externally and internally for Calixta. Chopin's depiction of Calixta's sexual liberation and fulfillment outside of her marriage is an early step in the fight to bridge the gap between women's bodies and their sociopolitical lives. By presenting female sexuality in a way that is enlightening rather than degrading, Chopin helps destigmatize labels such as *whore,* which have been used to shame women for acting outside of traditional gender expectations.

Peer Reviewer's Comments

1. A transition would help link this paragraph with the previous one.
2. At the beginning of the paragraph, after the first sentence, add a short description or explanation of what is happening in the scene.
3. The quotation from the text doesn't help explain your claim. Anyway, you left out a word.
4. Perhaps you could add a quotation about the storm.
5. Can you clarify the relationship between the storm and Calixta's self-realization?

Final Version

> When Calixta acts outside of societal norms, **however**, she discovers the freedom of self-expression and passion. **All of the parts of her womanhood that have no place in the society in which she lives have been repressed until this one moment. In this scene, Chopin takes possession of the term *whore* and redefines Calixta's behavior as a transformative awakening.** Chopin's diction evokes a spiritual transcendence that allows Calixta to exist momentarily outside social norms that exist only in the physical plane of existence: "when he possessed her, they seemed to swoon together at the very borderland of life's mystery." The affair becomes a vehicle that allows Calixta to get to a place of true self-expression. The storm, an aspect of nature or the natural world, acts as the catalyst in Calixta's natural self-realization of womanhood. As the storm breaks externally, it also breaks internally for Calixta. Chopin's depiction of Calixta's sexual liberation and fulfillment outside of her marriage is an early step in the fight to bridge the gap between women's bodies and their sociopolitical lives. By presenting female sexuality in a way that is enlightening rather than degrading, Chopin helps destigmatize labels such as *whore,* which have been used to shame women for acting outside of traditional gender expectations.

16.6 Editing Focus: Literary Works Live in the Present

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Apply methods commonly used for analysis and interpretation in writing.
- Demonstrate competent use of the literary present tense in textual analysis.

Although some texts may have been written years ago, they live in the present. This expression means that when you analyze a literary text such as a story, play, poem, or novel, you use a form of the present tense in your discussion. Narration in the story may be in the past tense—the narrator tells the story as though it has already happened—but your discussion of the literary work is done in the present tense. Characters *do* this or *say* that. The leaves *fall* or the wind is *howling*, even though in the text, the leaves *fell* and the wind *was howling*. Your discussion nevertheless remains in the present tense. Also, when discussing the author in relation to the literary text, use the present tense, even if the author is no longer living or wrote the text in the past. Look at these examples:

Incorrect: The narrator *stated* that the time is now.
Correct: The narrator *states* that the time is now.
Incorrect: Kate Chopin *seemed* to sympathize with Calixta.
Correct: Kate Chopin *seems* to sympathize with Calixta.
Incorrect: At the end, Clarisse *was* happy to remain ignorant about her husband and Calixta.
Correct: At the end, Clarisse *is* happy to remain ignorant about her husband and Calixta.

Use the Literary Present Tense with Consistency

Although the present tense is used in literary discussions and references to literary texts, some instances will occur in which you have to distinguish between times of events. Thus, using the present tense may not apply to all actions within a text. The characters within a text often have done something, or something has happened, in the past—before the action of the story. In such cases, refer to these past actions in the past tense. Also, use the past tense when referring to the author and events in the author's life that do not relate directly to the text. See the examples below:

Incorrect: Kate Chopin *is* born in 1850.
Correct: Kate Chopin *was* born in 1850.
Incorrect: Alcée *reminds* Calixta of what *happens* in Assumption years ago.
Incorrect: Alcée *reminded* Calixta of what *happened* in Assumption years ago.
Correct: Alcée *reminds* Calixta of what *happened* in Assumption years ago.

When revising and editing your textual analysis, review it for consistency and clarity in literary present tense when you discuss the text, events within the text, and the author's relationship to it. Use the past tense, however, when dealing with information outside the text, such as historical context or events related to the author's life. Be sure to distinguish between past and present events by using the correct tense. For more about the **literary present tense**, see Verbs.

16.7 Evaluation: Self-Directed Assessment

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Apply formats and design features for different kinds of texts.
- Assess your writing for language, clarity, coherence, and rhetorical choices, and by using a rubric.

Many writers find it difficult to assess their own work. Therefore, they rely on insights from someone outside of the process. While such insights may be useful in helping writers find their way, writers can review their own work either before someone else does or when outside reviewers are unavailable.

As a student writer, you might choose to read your work aloud or print the work in hard copy to read in a different medium. Close to the end of the process is a good time to conduct a self-directed assessment to note whether the points made, the organization, the tone, and the style of the work are helping you achieve goals for the project, whether personal, professional, or academic. You might think of this process as a type of reverse outlining, as you go back to the basic structure of your writing. Based on your rubric or evaluative criteria, create points to check on your own.

Rubric

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
5 **Skillful**	The text always adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using the literary present tense as discussed in Section 16.6. The text also shows ample evidence of the writer's intent to consciously meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	All paragraphs in the paper reflect its purpose, stated in the thesis, and allow for a thorough analysis of a literary work. The overall organization is clear, and ideas are connected with effective transitions. Paragraphs have topic sentences and proceed logically from them to support the thesis.	The tone and language choices are well suited to the audience and purpose. The work reflects thought, fairness, general comprehension, and keen awareness of the rhetorical situation.
4 **Accomplished**	The text usually adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using the literary present tense as discussed in Section 16.6. The text also shows some evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	Most paragraphs in the paper reflect its purpose, stated in the thesis, and allow for a strong analysis of a literary work. The overall organization is clear, and most ideas are connected with transitions. Most paragraphs have topic sentences and proceed logically from them to support the thesis.	The tone and language choices are usually well suited to the audience and purpose. The work reflects thought, fairness, comprehension, and reasonable awareness of the rhetorical situation.
3 **Capable**	The text generally adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using the literary present tense as discussed in Section 16.6. The text also shows limited evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	Some paragraphs in the paper reflect its purpose, which may be stated in the thesis, and may not provide a strong focus for analysis of a literary work. The overall organization is discernible, and some ideas are connected with transitions. Most paragraphs have topic sentences but may not proceed logically from them to support the thesis.	The tone and language choices are somewhat suited to the audience and purpose. The work reflects some thought, fairness, comprehension, and reasonable awareness of the rhetorical situation

TABLE 16.4

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
2 **Developing**	The text occasionally adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using the literary present tense as discussed in Section 16.6. The text also shows emerging evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	Some paragraphs in the paper reflect its purpose, which may or may not be stated in the thesis. The thesis provides minimal focus for analysis of a literary work. Other paragraphs are rambling, unfocused, and out of logical order. There is little overall organization and little use of effective transitions. Most paragraphs lack topic sentences or have more than one.	Lapses in tone and language choices make the writing unsuited to the audience and purpose. The work reflects little thought, some unfairness, questionable comprehension, and minimal awareness of the rhetorical situation.
1 **Beginning**	The text does not adhere to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using the literary present tense as discussed in Section 16.6. The text also shows little to no evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	Few, if any, paragraphs in the paper reflect its purpose, which may or may not be stated in the thesis. The thesis provides little or no focus for analysis of a literary work. Other paragraphs are rambling, unfocused, and out of logical order. There is little or no obvious organization and little or no use of effective transitions. Most or all paragraphs lack topic sentences, have more than one, or are insufficiently developed.	Frequent lapses in tone and language choices make the writing unsuited to the audience and purpose. The work reflects little or no thought, fairness, accurate comprehension, or awareness of the rhetorical situation.

TABLE 16.4

16.8 Spotlight on … Humanities

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Describe various disciplines in the humanities.
- Evaluate employment opportunities for graduates with humanities degrees.

Although all college instructors value good writing, each area of study has its own set of criteria by which writing is judged. For instance, the loose informal style and speculative content of a reflective essay might be appropriate for an English class but inappropriate for an anthropology class in which the instructor would expect the more formal structures established in that subject area.

As a discipline, the humanities include subjects that focus on human culture and values. Some subjects are literature, languages, classics, art history, film, musicology, philosophy, religion, and often history, which sometimes is placed in the social sciences. The humanities are the foundation of liberal arts and, as such, include a wide variety of writing genres. Research reports, biographies, literary analyses, ethnographies, quantitative reports, proposals, books, journal articles, poetry, film scripts, novels, stories, technical writing, and professional documents are forms of writing particular to the humanities.

As a rule, knowledge in the humanities focuses on texts and on individual ideas, speculations, insights, and imaginative connections. Interpretation in the humanities is thus relatively subjective. Accordingly, much of the writing and research in the humanities is characterized by personal involvement, lively language, and speculative or open-ended conclusions.

The field of English includes the study of not only literature but of literary theory and history, and not only composition but creative and technical writing. In addition, English departments often include linguistics, journalism, folklore, women's studies, cultural or ethnic studies, and film. In other words, within even one discipline, you might be asked to write several distinct types of papers: personal experience essays for a composition course, analyses for a literature course, abstracts or case studies for a linguistics course, procedural texts for a technical writing course, and short stories for a creative writing course. Consequently, any observations about the different kinds of knowledge and the differing conventions for writing about them are only generalizations. The more carefully you study any one discipline, the more complex it becomes, and the harder it is to make a generalization that does not have numerous explanations.

Careers in the Humanities



Because humanities subjects emphasize critical thinking and clear writing, the skills humanities students obtain are valued in many fields other than the most obvious ones. Humanities majors have gone on to careers in law, medicine (humanities plus pre-med), advertising, journalism, TV and film writing and production, public relations, graphic design, teaching, technical and medical/scientific writing, human resources, and many others. For more information about career opportunities for humanities students, see these sites:

- Humanities and Social Sciences Careers (https://openstax.org/r/Humanities)
- Top 10 Highest Paying Jobs for Liberal Arts Majors (https://openstax.org/r/Top-10-Highest)
- 25 Great Jobs for Humanities Majors (https://openstax.org/r/Great-Jobs)

Students' Stories

Despite strong interest in the humanities—especially in reading, writing, and language—some students avoid humanities subjects as majors because they think they won't find jobs after graduation. Such fear, however, is unwarranted, as many organizations actively seek students who major in languages or in other humanities disciplines. These graduates are valued for their ability to interpret and analyze text and to write clear, concise, and compelling prose. Moreover, employers realize that students who concentrate on studying people—whether real or fictional—develop insights into human behavior and understanding of how to deal with it. For example, these students who graduated with degrees in humanities subjects have found rewarding work in humanities-related and business fields.

Gabriela Torres majored in film studies, with a minor in theater. Although more interested in the technical aspects of both, she took creative writing classes and enjoyed performing in several college productions. Soon after graduation, Gabriela joined the human resources (HR) department of midsized corporation. Her job is to train new hires and conduct in-service workshops for current employees. Recently her role has expanded to writing, producing, and acting in training videos in which she uses the skills she learned in college—and more.

Derrek Wilson became an international studies major after he received a summer stipend to study in Europe. After only a few weeks there and trips to historic sites, Derrek says he got "hooked on history." The broad focus of his interdisciplinary major allowed him to take courses in humanities subjects: history, geography, religion, archaeology, and world literature. He had studied Spanish in high school and continued in college. Derrek graduated last year and now works as an international program coordinator for his university. Responsible for logistics of foreign students coming to the United States and for American students going abroad, he oversees housing accommodations, student visas, and travel arrangements. He loves his job and the time he gets to spend in different countries, but he plans to go to law school in a few years—with, you guessed it, a specialty in international and immigration law.

Despite his parents' warnings that he'd never find a good job, Nick Marelli majored in English. He put his literary interests to work in college as managing editor of the literary magazine and arts editor of the newspaper. When he graduated, he applied, on a whim (and to please his parents), for a management trainee position at a large insurance company. Thinking he would get nowhere without business courses, he was surprised when a recruiter called him for an interview. The interviewer then told him that the company actively seeks English majors because they know how to read carefully, digest and summarize information, think critically, and write clearly, concisely, and correctly. Nick says, "I was surprised when I heard someone other than an English teacher say that. I really like my work, where I'm learning a lot on the spot rather than in a classroom."

Thinking, Writing, and Publishing

Critical writing requires critical thinking. When an individual or collaborative team articulates their perspective, they provide new knowledge for audiences. In essence, all texts have potential to create new knowledge. A writer of any type of text has the potential to enter a conversation and show audiences new ways to look at a subject.

Learning how to write analytically and critically offers a skill set for crafting various genres, such as information reports, proposals, cost/benefit analyses, instructions, and so on. After you have completed your analysis for this chapter, consider submitting it to an open-access academic journal that highlights the work of undergraduate students in the humanities, such as these:

Undergraduate Journal of Humanistic Studies (https://openstax.org/r/Undergraduate)

16.9 Portfolio: The Academic and the Personal

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Reflect on the development of composing processes and how those processes affect your work.
- Identify your strengths in writing and consider how to continue to develop your writing process.

Reflective Writing: Genres of Reflective Writing

Reflective writing is not limited to a single genre. Because it is highly personal, it is most frequent in, but certainly not limited to, diaries, journals, autobiographies, and memoirs. One common way that it appears is in letters or essays that writers craft to reflect on, or think about, their writing process for a particular text they have written. Consider the following suggestions when you write reflectively about this assignment for your ongoing portfolio compilation:

- Write this letter, essay, or response as you would to a friend—be kind to yourself and your process, but be realistic as well.
- Highlight what you think are your present capabilities and what you would like to strengthen.
- Specifically discuss and illustrate—by giving specific examples—how well you have met the assignment objectives listed under Evaluation: Self-Directed Assessment.

To guide your portfolio reflection, answer these questions:

- What did you learn about yourself and/or the writing process in the course of writing your textual analysis?
- What did you learn about the topic and/or about writing in general?
- Which part of the writing process was most beneficial to you: drafting, peer review, conferences, or something else?
- How successfully did you address the assignment guidelines?
- How might you change your writing process to better support your growth as a writer—for example, time management, change in drafting methods, more focus on rubric, extended research, more focus on the final draft before submission?

Further Reading

George, Diana. "Changing the Face of Poverty: Nonprofits and the Problem of Representation." *Popular Literacy: Studies in Cultural Practices and Poetics*, edited by John Trimbur, University of Pittsburgh Press, 2001.

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